

Rock de Vocht



AI & Data Consultant · AI Governance, ISO/IEC 42001 · Solution Architect · Technical Leader

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Location Wellington, New Zealand

Education MSc Computer Science, University of Auckland

Languages Dutch, English, French, German

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

AI and data consultant with a 30-year record spanning hands-on engineering, solution architecture and executive leadership.

I most recently led an AI software company through ISO/IEC 42001 certification, standing up its AI management system and owning AI governance, risk and audit readiness, after six years as Chief Scientific Officer of SimSage delivering an enterprise semantic search platform with production AI workflows and ISO/IEC 27001 experience. My consulting record spans pre-sales solution architecture at Datacom, CTO-level advisory at Booktrack, search solution consulting for a Fortune 1000 US company and UK enterprise clients at SimSage, and current engagements delivering architecture reviews, LLM benchmarking and whitepapers. I am equally at home presenting to a board and pairing with an engineer, and I lead in a collaborative style that consistently puts results ahead of ego.

ISO 42001

CERTIFICATION LED

30+

YEARS IN TECHNOLOGY

2

COMPANIES CO-FOUNDED

10

ENGINEERS LED

CAREER HISTORY

Senior Developer (Contract)

CURRENT

Jun 2026 – Present

Nylon · Legal AI Platform

ongoing

- **ISO/IEC 42001 certification:** Led Nylon's ISO/IEC 42001 certification programme end to end: scoped and stood up the AI management system, drove the AI policy, risk and impact assessment work, embedded governance into the engineering lifecycle and prepared the organisation for audit.
- **LLM benchmarking & advisory:** Investigated large language model performance across the product's workloads and authored a whitepaper capturing the methodology, benchmark results and recommendations adopted by the engineering team.
- **Evaluation tooling:** Designed and built a reusable LLM evaluation harness in Node.js, giving the team a repeatable way to measure model quality, latency and cost as models and prompts change.
- **Architecture review:** Reviewed the new document processing architecture and delivered optimisations to ingestion and retrieval, improving throughput and answer quality across the pipeline.
- **Hands-on build:** Worked with Qdrant for vector storage and retrieval, AWS for pipeline infrastructure, and Python plus PDF extraction technologies for document parsing and ingestion.

FOCUS AI governance · ISO/IEC 42001 · LLM evaluation & benchmarking · RAG pipelines · Node.js · TypeScript · Python · Qdrant · AWS

Chief Scientific Officer & Co-Founder

Jan 2020 – Apr 2026

SimSage UK Ltd. · Cambridge, UK

6 yrs 4 mos

- **Executive leadership:** Set the technical strategy and roadmap for an enterprise AI search company, translating between the board, customers and the engineering team.
- **Client consulting:** Consulted on search solutions with a Fortune 1000 US company and enterprise clients across the UK, from requirements and demonstrations through to delivered capability.
- **System architecture:** Owned the architecture and delivery of a graph-based enterprise semantic search engine, from data model and service decomposition through to deployment topology.
- **Production AI:** Designed production AI workflows integrating Gemini, OpenAI and Copilot, and directed the build of a 250k+ line codebase with 30+ enterprise API connectors (SharePoint, OneDrive, Google Drive).
- **Security & data governance:** Designed the security protocols and RBAC model governing sensitive enterprise data across every connector and tenant, and helped drive SimSage's ISO/IEC 27001 information security management work.

- **Team leadership:** Led and mentored a team of engineers, setting standards, reviewing code and holding delivery ownership across the full SDLC, with event-driven infrastructure on Kafka, Kubernetes and Terraform.

STACK C# · Kotlin (JVM) · Java · Python · React + TypeScript · SQL · CQL · Kafka · Kubernetes · Terraform

Developer (Contract)

May 2018 – Dec 2019

MBIE / NZ Immigration · Wellington

1 yr 8 mos

- Designed and ran the unstructured data integration and NLP processing of 170M text records for signal analysis in a government risk context.
- Consulted on NLP methods and solutions for internal record processing across the agency.
- Drove C# .NET and SQL development on Azure, and deployed machine learning for data quality analysis using Python.

STACK C# .NET · SQL · Python · Azure · Linux · NLP · machine learning

NLP Specialist

Mar 2016 – May 2018

Booktrack.com · Auckland

2 yrs 3 mos

- **Technical advisory:** Consulted with Booktrack CTO on overall development strategy and on machine learning and natural language processing direction, delivering consultations and demonstrations of ML and NLP capability.
- **Applied research:** Researched and developed neural networks for emotional text analysis, context understanding and speech-to-text within the company's core IP.
- **Build & platform:** Delivered core development in C#, SQL, Java and Python across Google Cloud and Azure, on Kubernetes and Docker.

STACK C# · Java · Python · SQL · Kubernetes · Docker · Google Cloud · Azure · neural networks

Developer / DevOps (Contract)

Jan 2015 – Mar 2016

Verifone · Wellington

1 yr 3 mos

- Managed CI/CD and DevOps operations in a payments environment, owning complex technical issues escalated to level-three support.

Chief Scientist & Co-Founder

May 2008 – Jan 2015

SYL Search · Wellington

6 yrs 9 mos

- **Government consulting:** Consulted with many NZ Government departments on technical search implementations; the engine was adopted by MOT, NZTA and MPI.
- **Architecture:** Defined the technical roadmap and designed and built an innovative semantic search engine for information retrieval at scale.
- **Team lead:** Led a development team of five through the full SDLC and IP creation, mentoring developers throughout.
- **Integration:** Designed and managed complex integrations with external APIs, SharePoint, CRM and social platforms.

STACK Java · C# · SQL · Cassandra · semantic search · API integration

Senior Architect, Microsoft Team

Jan 2004 – May 2008

Datacom · Wellington

4 yrs 5 mos

- **Consulting:** Drove solution architecture for Datacom's enterprise customers as a member of the internal Datacom Architecture Solution Group, providing pre-sales technical assistance and comprehensive technical writing.
- **Delivery:** Competed in and won large projects with teams of up to 10 engineers; acted as team lead, mentored developers and ran internal education sessions.

STACK .NET Framework · ASP.NET · C# · SQL Server · SharePoint · Windows Server

EARLIER CAREER

Video Games Developer, Takapuna · C++ programmer for Xbox titles 2002–2004

Developer, Datacom Auckland · Visual Basic development 1998–2002

Developer, Terabyte Interactive · Led the America's Cup Virtual Spectator development team 1997–1998

Network System Administrator, University of Auckland · Windows NT network administration; level-one support for ~20,000 students 1996

Developer, University of Auckland Language Laboratories · C and HyperCard developer for student language software 1995–1996

AI governance & certification: ISO/IEC 42001 AI management systems from scoping through certification, backed by hands-on ISO/IEC 27001 experience at SimSage; AI policy, risk and impact assessment; responsible AI controls embedded into the engineering lifecycle; audit preparation. I connect governance to the underlying engineering reality rather than treating it as paperwork.

What I advise on: AI strategy and adoption roadmaps; LLM selection, evaluation and benchmarking; retrieval and RAG architecture; enterprise data platforms, integration surfaces and security boundaries; architecture reviews with written findings and whitepapers.

How I work: I design in the open and validate by building. Decisions are written down, walked through with stakeholders, and proven with a running slice before the wider build commits to them. I stay hands-on so the advice stays honest.

Engagement history: pre-sales solution architecture and technical writing for enterprise customers at Datacom; CTO-level advisory on ML and NLP strategy at Booktrack; search solution consulting for a Fortune 1000 US company, UK enterprise clients and NZ Government departments; NLP consulting at MBIE; architecture review, benchmarking, whitepaper delivery and certification leadership at Nylon. Methodologies: RM-ODP, micro-services, SaaS, Agile and Waterfall.

LEADERSHIP & MANAGEMENT

Formal leadership roles: Chief Scientific Officer at SimSage UK, Chief Scientist at SYL Search, and Senior Architect / Team Lead at Datacom. **Team size:** up to 10 engineers, junior through senior. **Ownership:** full-SDLC delivery accountability, technical roadmaps, stakeholder management and developer mentoring.

Working style: I resolve team conflicts through collaboration and delivery issues through hands-on investigation, and I take responsibility for my team's mistakes. I mentor junior staff closely, share knowledge freely, and assign engineers where their strengths let them shine.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

AI Governance & Assurance

ISO/IEC 42001 AI management systems, ISO/IEC 27001 information security management, AI policy and risk frameworks, AI impact assessment, model evaluation and benchmarking, audit readiness, data governance, security and privacy by design.

AI, ML & Search

Generative AI (Gemini, OpenAI, Copilot), LLM evaluation harnesses, RAG and document ingestion pipelines, Qdrant vector search, NLP and neural networks, semantic / graph search, machine learning.

Architecture & Design

Solution and software architecture, micro-service and SaaS design, event-driven architecture (Kafka), domain and data modelling, big-data retrieval design, API and integration architecture, RBAC and security design, technical roadmaps, technical writing.

Languages

SQL²⁸ JavaScript / TypeScript²⁷ C# .NET²² C/C++²⁰ Java¹⁸ CQL¹⁶ Kotlin⁸ Python⁸

Data & Streaming

Apache Cassandra¹⁶ Microsoft SQL²² Apache Spark¹⁰ Qdrant, Kafka, Redis (Valkey), Apache Superset · big-data retrieval and code optimisation.

Cloud & Infrastructure

AWS, Azure, Google Cloud · Docker²² Kubernetes⁸ Terraform⁶ Ansible · KeyCloak · network administration²⁰ · CI/CD via GitLab and GitHub.

Security & Identity

RBAC, Azure Entra, AD / LDAP, AES encryption, hashing (bcrypt, sha256), SSH, HTTPS certificate management, Microsoft Graph, DNS configuration.

Platforms & Frameworks

Windows Server²² Ubuntu Server¹⁸ SharePoint¹⁶ Nginx, IIS · Node.js, React, Angular, .NET Core and Framework, ASP.NET, Bash, PowerShell.

Leadership & Consulting

Team leadership, mentoring, stakeholder management, customer and C-suite consultation, pre-sales, executive communication, collaborative conflict resolution, interdisciplinary collaboration.

Years of experience: superscript numbers show years of hands-on experience; SQL²⁸ means 28 years of SQL.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Master of Science in Computer Science University of Auckland

Focus: natural language processing, grammar, language semantics and knowledge representation.

Bachelor of Science (Honours) in Computer Science University of Auckland

Machine Learning Certification

Stanford University (Coursera) · May 2013

Artificial intelligence and deep-learning neural networks.